

as Antonelli came into his own. Just 18 years old and in his debut season, he is quickly proving he belongs on this stage.

Starting from P4, Antonelli launched a fierce attack from the opening lap, managing to snatch third place from Oscar Piastri, the championship leader. For Antonelli, it wasn't just a shot at a podium finish but also the determination to end a string of poor results over the previous three rounds. When the chequered flag fell under the Safety Car, Antonelli secured his maiden Formula One podium, becoming the third-youngest driver to do so at 18 years and 294 days.

But while Mercedes had a near-perfect weekend, drama unfolded elsewhere — particularly within McLaren.

A costly collision

Heading into Montreal, the intra-team battle between Piastri and Lando Norris had been heating up. Just 10 points separated the pair, and McLaren had committed to the 'papaya rules', a 'let them race' approach, encouraging clean, respectful on-track competition without the interference of team orders. But it could carry serious implications for the championship.

It was on lap 67 that things took a turn. Piastri, chasing Antonelli for third, found himself closely followed by Norris. The Briton had already made one failed attempt to pass, and on his second try, down the start-finish straight, he misjudged his braking, approaching with too much speed and too little caution. Norris clipped the rear of Piastri's car and then hit the wall, suffering extensive damage and retiring on the spot.

It was a moment reminiscent of McLaren's own mishap at the same track — when Hamilton collided with Jenson Button in 2011. This incident, too, could carry long-term consequences. While Norris was quick to take full responsibility for the mistake, the incident was more than just an unfortunate racing moment.

It was a significant blow to his title challenge, especially in a season where his form has already been shaky. In contrast, Piastri escaped without damage, held onto fourth place, and extended his championship lead to 22 points — a major swing at a crucial juncture in the season.

Momentum shift

With the race finishing under the Safety Car, Russell and Verstappen, two drivers who have built a reputation for their sharp on- and off-track duels, did experience a bit of friction.



Off-track: Lando Norris exits his battered car after the collision. AP

Though there was a moment of dispute where they bickered over their driving behind the SC, they crossed the line in the same order they started: Russell first, Verstappen second. There were no last-lap fireworks this time, just a well-managed win for Mercedes and another strong result for Red Bull.

For Mercedes, though, this victory meant more than just 25 points. It was proof that its rebuild is bearing fruit. The car is getting quicker, and the blend of experience in Russell and promise in Antonelli is starting to deliver results. While they're still a step behind the absolute leaders, the Silver Arrows are closing the gap, setting themselves up for a more positive season.

THREE-PEAT FOR FERRARI AT LE MANS



Ferrari took victory at the 2025 24 Hours of Le Mans, securing a historic three-peat in the prestigious event. The #83 AF Corse was driven by former F1 driver Robert Kubica (in pic), Yifei Ye and Phil Hanson, and it was the first outright privateer win at Le Mans since 2005.

Along with being the third different Ferrari to win in as many years, it was the third different driver line-up. Kubica, the first Pole to win this event, produced the heroics, as the former Grand Prix-winner completed 43 per cent of the winning car's laps, while Ye became the first Chinese winner and Hanson, the 35th British victor.

